



PTI

ASHOK CHAVAN

Infighting may spoil Chavan's unblemished record of delivering the goods

↑ Chavan is seen as a credible leader who delivered 17 of the 48 seats in the LS elections. The rise of the MNS and weakening of the NCP, its ally, have only served as a boost for him as it will help the Congress increase its tally from the 69 seats it won last time.

↓ Several Congress loyalists are angry over ticket distribution, which can spark rebellion in its ranks. The anti-incumbency factor, after 10 years of the Democratic Front Government, due to power and water woes in rural areas can also dent the party's chances.

CHAVAN AWARDS A TICKET TO A HOPEFUL

whom the impending elections are a litmus test. At stake are careers of behemoths like Nationalist Congress Party's (NCP) Sharad Pawar, BJP's Gopinath Munde, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena's (MNS) Raj Thackeray and Chief Minister Ashok Chavan. Who wins this election will have little to do with the

public opinion. The outcome will be determined by how much damage the behemoths inflict on their enemies. Just as Uddhav's real threat is Raj's MNS, Chavan's victory will be determined by how well rebel candidates of the NCP do in his party's constituencies.

Real issues like inflation

and drought be damned, personal rivalry is the dominant theme this year as politicians are pulling out all the stops to defeat their biggest bete noire. At the receiving end of most of the venom is Uddhav.

Realising the determination of Raj as well as that of the Congress's Narayan Rane to destroy the Sena, Uddhav is concentrating his energies on rural areas, which is opening up a new frontier for a party whose strongholds have largely been urban areas. A senior state BJP leader feels that this election will throw up many surprises as Pawar is incensed with the Congress. "Like last time, Pawar will attempt to cut its ally to size by sponsoring rebellion in Congress constituencies, while the MNS and Rane will work against the Sena."

With 10,000 independents in the fray, clearly rebellion will break many backs this time. Pawar, the big daddy of Maharashtra politics, should know since he is the master of the game. After the drubbing the NCP got in western Maharashtra, compared to its ally Congress, during the Lok Sabha elections, the NCP's very existence is under threat. With the Congress rubbing its nose to the ground over seat-sharing, Pawar is incensed enough to keep the Congress out in the cold. Rumour has it that the Congress's Digvijay Singh has even convinced 30 MLAs to defect from the NCP to the his party in case Pawar does not toe the line. However, all the crossing over will happen,

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